

section part and bind it to the layout, to be used in further stages.

Have an eye on the price all through

One of the main influencing factors in designing a system is the budgetary constraint. Owners of PCB123, Sunstone Circuits, claim to offer PCB manufacturing services at nominal rates. As they use the tool, users have the option to specify order quantity, and pricing for the same is highlighted. They can go ahead and

is do a manufacturing design and fabrication rule check. Users can do the same check at the layout design stage and go deeper into each error to fix it.

The errors and warnings that show up must be corrected or signed off as not being relevant to the design before going in for the next stage. By logging on to their account in Sunstone, users can have an electrical and isolation check, and get assembly done, too. They then have to just send off the

Shortcuts to find your way through

As you move on to extensive designing, it becomes a pain to have to move the mouse and click on options for every small action you want to perform. This is where the shortcut keys come to view. Once you get used to these, manoeuvring through the design becomes a cake-walk.

PCB123 helps you get acquainted with the keys easily by providing a key-assignment view, which lets you scroll over the keys on the keyboard while highlighting the shortcut and what each shortcut does. Shortcuts also crop up on the various menus available and show up along with tips for using the tool as you move over the tools section on your screen. With each version of the software, effort is being made to make the tool as user-friendly as possible, at the same time improving the efficiency of your design process.

order the PCB from the same menu at any stage.

There is also a bill of materials (BOM) menu that breaks down the number of components in the design, and the components' cost. A section specifying Digikey part number allows users to check the latest price online and even place an order on Digikey by automatically filling out the form for them. By a search from Digikey portal, they can cross-reference to make sure that the part specified by the tool is exactly the one they need.

The BOM sheet also allows users to add custom content, to may be order solder or pin connectors to put your PCB into action. A part that is already in the design, like a battery, may not be deleted, but can be hidden. This effectively performs the same action as a delete from BOM table.

Verify before taking plunge

When you click on the order button, the first thing that PCB123 does

order file to Sunstone and wait for the PCB to be ready.

Resources aplenty

The 3D section of the tool lets users visualise how each change they make on the schematic or layout will reflect in the PCB manufacturing stage. As this can be seen not just once the entire design is complete, it puts them at a better place to predict and create according to requirements.

To aid newcomers to PCB123, their website, www.pcb123.com, features a number of videos showing users how to go about the design process. For a regular user, there are videos to highlight the usage of newly-introduced features in the latest versions. With a live chat feature on the website and support on Sunstone website, advanced problems can be solved easily. **EFY**

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Are You In Suspense?

Are you wondering what happened to your order or payment, even after a fortnight? But did you mention your name and address clearly while sending payment, and what the payment was for?

We get several payments every month without adequate instructions or even identity of the person sending the payment. As a result we are unable to take appropriate action on these, till we get a complaint - if at all.

At EFY, we want you to be our satisfied customer. So please do let us know in case your payment or instructions are not even acknowledged within a fortnight. We are not that lazy!

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